

After the Story: Don't Answer When It Calls Your Name

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A companion study to *Pen Argyl*

Back to the Basement

Scoot in closer to the fire. We're going back down Tyler Morgan's basement stairs, past the laundry basket on the third step.

It's Halloween of 2021 in Pen Argyl. The town lost a whole year of parties to the virus, and every kid wants one back. There's a pumpkin candle on the dryer, a bowl of candy corn nobody touches, and a monster movie on with the sound off. Brandon brings out a talking board in a long flat box and tells everybody, "It's a game. They sell it at Target." For a while it is a game. Then the plastic heart spells B. U. G., the one name only Kayleigh's brother Danny ever called her. Danny drowned in the Albion hole that July. Now the board says he's cold and alone in the water, and it wants Kayleigh at the quarry ledge at midnight.

Our narrator was thirteen, with knees shaking so bad it took a hand on the washing machine to stand up. But the narrator knew one thing for certain, from that church parking lot three weeks before Danny died, when Danny said it himself: "If anything ever happens to me, I'm with Jesus." So the narrator called the board a liar, planted a sneaker on it, and ordered it out in the name of Jesus Christ. Then came the second move. The narrator took Kayleigh by the wrist and ran.

Tonight we're going to talk about why both of those moves were right.

Questions to Sit With

1. Read 1 John 4:1-3. The voice on that board knew a private nickname. Can a voice know your secrets and still lie to you? What test does John give us to tell?
2. Read 2 Corinthians 5:8 and Luke 16:27-31. Where did Danny say he'd be? What does Scripture say about the dead coming back to call on the living?
3. Read 1 Corinthians 10:14 and 1 John 4:4 side by side. The narrator rebuked the board and then ran. Why does a believer who stands in the power of Jesus still use two feet?

The Teaching: Test the Voice, Then Run

Start with the oldest trick in the story. The board knew Kayleigh's name. It knew the name Danny used, and it knew where he died. That's what made it so cruel, and so convincing. A grieving girl hears her brother's pet name come across a piece of cardboard, and her heart wants to believe it so bad she reaches for that heart with both hands.

Rick Renner wrote a short study guide on Halloween called *Trick or Treat*, and he goes straight at this. He traces the holiday back to an old Celtic festival where people believed the wall between the living and the dead got thin on October 31, and the dead could walk again. He calls it what Scripture calls it, necromancy, which means trying to talk with the dead. Then he says what those people really reach. They're "connecting with demonic spirits that are familiar with the person they are trying to reach" (Renner, *Trick or Treat*, 31). Two pages on, he warns that "those entities might even appear as people that once lived" (Renner, *Trick or Treat*, 33).

That's the board in Tyler's basement. It knew one little word. It used the one true thing it had to carry a pile of lies: that Danny was cold, that he was alone, that he needed his sister to come to the water in the dark. God warned Israel about this a long time before Pen Argyl. He told them not to let anybody among them consult the dead or call up spirits, because those practices are detestable to Him (Deuteronomy 18:10-12). Isaiah asked why anybody would go to the dead on behalf of the living, when they could go to their God (Isaiah 8:19).

Renner's list of occult practices names the brand right out: "Ouija boards," which he calls "a game where an amulet moves by the power of evil spirits telling the future" (Renner, *Trick or Treat*, 41). Brandon said it was a game too. Renner and Brandon used the same word and meant two different things.

So how did a thirteen-year-old know it was lying? By doing what John told the churches to do. Don't believe every spirit, John said, but test the spirits to see whether they're from God (1 John 4:1). However much a spirit knows about you, John's test is what it says about Jesus. Every spirit that confesses Jesus Christ has come in the flesh is from God, and every spirit that won't confess Him isn't (1 John 4:2-3). Look at what the board said. It never once said the name of Jesus. It talked about cold water and loneliness and a midnight ledge. It tried to pull a girl away from her brother's confession and toward a quarry.

Renner wrote a longer book, *Seducing Spirits and Doctrines of Demons*, and he spends a whole chapter on testing what comes at us from the spirit world. He says God commends a believer who tests, for wanting to know the truth. "When you test the spirits, this does not mean that you are opposing God or walking in unbelief," he writes (Renner, *Seducing Spirits*, ch. 8). He gives five questions to ask, and two of them would've cracked that board wide open. What does it produce in your life? Whom does it glorify? His answer to the last one is short: "If it is from God, it will glorify Jesus" (Renner, *Seducing Spirits*, ch. 9). That board produced terror and a midnight invitation to a drowning place. It glorified a dead boy's nickname and never his Lord.

Now hold that against what the narrator knew. The narrator had heard Danny's own words with the baptism water still dripping off his chin. Paul wrote that to be away from the body is to be at home with the Lord (2 Corinthians 5:8). In Jesus' story of the rich man and Lazarus, the rich man begs Abraham to send Lazarus back to warn his brothers, and Abraham tells him no, they have Moses and the Prophets (Luke 16:27-31). Danny was home, and no quarry hole on earth could hold him. The narrator won that night standing on two things, what Danny confessed and what God had already said, with both knees still shaking.

Then the narrator ran, and that matters just as much. Paul told the Corinthians to flee from idolatry (1 Corinthians 10:14). Renner says the Greek word there, *pheugo*, means to run as fast as you can, and "it pictures one's feet flying as he runs from a situation" (Renner, *Trick or Treat*, 16). He knows people will quote 1 John 4:4 back at him, that the One in you is greater than the one in the world, and he agrees. But he points out that the same John ended the same letter by telling his little children to keep themselves from idols (1 John 5:21). Renner compares it to standing at a cliff. You might not fall just because you're near the edge, but playing there makes slipping a lot more likely (Renner, *Trick or Treat*, 17). His advice is plain: "Your greatest way of escape is using your two feet" (Renner, *Trick or Treat*, 45).

The narrator's grandmother taught the same thing. Don't argue with it any more than you'd argue with a snake in the woodpile. Speak the Name, then get out of the basement.

And then the fire. Tyler's dad broke that board across his knee and laid it on the logs. That's an old move too. In Ephesus, people who had practiced magic came to faith in Jesus and brought their scrolls out into the open and burned them in front of everybody, even though they were worth a fortune (Acts 19:19). Renner tells a story from that same city, one church tradition holds

about Timothy, the young pastor Paul wrote to. During a pagan parade on Curetes Street, the tradition says Timothy went out and "told them to take off their masks and lay down their effigies," and the crowd beat him to death with their poles (Renner, *Trick or Treat*, 34). That story comes down to us by tradition, so we hold it loosely. What we can open and read is the letter Paul wrote to Timothy when he was young and afraid: God didn't give us a spirit of fear, but of power and love and a sound mind (2 Timothy 1:7).

That verse is a thirteen-year-old's small voice made bigger.

Around the Fire: Talk It Over and Take It Home

Talk about your own Octobers. Some of you grew up with a board in somebody's basement, or a sleepover with candles and a mirror. Say out loud what you played with and what came of it.

Renner says the people who sell these things call them games. Ask yourself whose game it was.

Talk about grief. The board went after the girl who was hurting most in that room. That's where the enemy always goes. If you've lost somebody who knew the Lord, you don't need a voice from a strange place to tell you where they are. Read 2 Corinthians 5:8 for yourself, the way the narrator read it twice to Kayleigh by flashlight. And if you've lost somebody and you don't know where they stood, take that to God in prayer and don't take it anywhere else.

Talk about the two moves, standing and running. Which one comes harder for you? Some of us are quick to run and slow to speak the Name. Some of us want to stand and argue all night with whatever's pushing the heart around. The narrator did both, in that order, and never stopped to explain it to anybody.

Try this, this week. If there's a board, a deck of cards, an app, or anything else in your house that promises to talk to the dead or tell you the future, take it outside and get rid of it. Burn it if you can do that safely, the way the Ephesians did. Pray over the room where it sat. Then learn 1 John 4:4 by heart, and 1 John 5:21 right behind it, because John put them in the same letter for a reason. And the next time a voice calls you by a name it shouldn't know, don't answer, and don't ask it anything. Speak the Name, and get your feet moving.

Works Cited

Renner, Rick. *Seducing Spirits and Doctrines of Demons*. N.p.: n.p., n.d.

Renner, Rick. *Trick or Treat: A Christian Response to Halloween*. Companion Study Guide.
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